▼ GLASSHOUSE



UNFINISHED BUSINESS

When BJP president **Nitin Nabin** told party workers in Ranchi on October 24 to be ready to bring the party back to power in Jharkhand, the calendar seemed to be running three years ahead. The next assembly election is not due till 2029, but the party has a geographical itch to scratch. Bihar, West Bengal, Chhattisgarh, Odisha and Uttar Pradesh, the five states bordering Jharkhand, all have BJP-led governments. On the saffron map, Jharkhand stands out like an uncoloured patch in a school atlas. Nabin's interest is not entirely cartographic, though. He reminded his audience that he was born in Ranchi and studied there, so this is not merely another electoral assignment. It might be a slightly long wait, but a party government in the state would be the perfect homecoming gift. Or does the BJP president have alternative plans to instal one sooner?

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▼ THE HILLS SEE RED

FAMILY BAGGAGE

Samajwadi Party chief **Akhilesh Yadav**'s alleged reference to people from Uttarakhand as "*ghuspaithiya* (infiltrators)" has given CM **Pushkar Singh Dhami** a chance to remind him of some uncomfortable family history. Calling it an insult to Uttarakhand, the BJP leader brought up the 1994 statehood agitation, particularly the police firing at Rampur Tiraha and violence in other places. The chief minister of undivided Uttar Pradesh then was Akhilesh's late father, Mulayam Singh Yadav.



Dhami also dragged the Congress into the controversy, asking whether the SP's ally endorsed the remark. Samajwadi leaders say their chief's comment was targeted at UP chief minister Yogi Adityanath's hill state origins, but suffice to say, it has given Dhami enough ammunition to target both rival parties. The statehood agitation is a chapter that still evokes strong emotions in Uttarakhand, and with the assembly election due in 2027, the saffron CM is sure to mine it for quite some time.